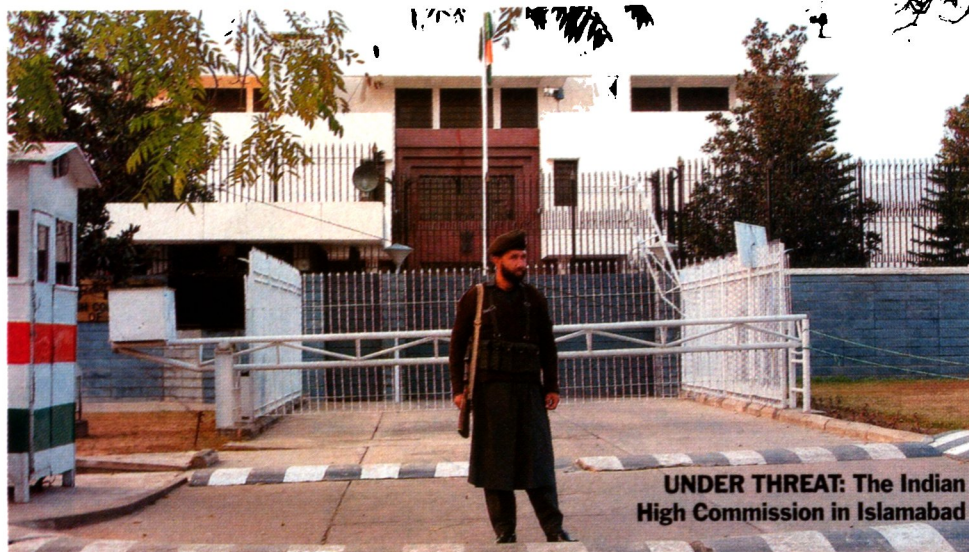


APPHOTO/ SAIED KHAN



**UNDER THREAT: The Indian High Commission in Islamabad**

## Dangerous Designs

**DELHI** Alarm bells have been ringing in South Block because of the worsening security situation in Islamabad following the assassination of former Pakistani premier Benazir Bhutto. But now there is a bigger cause for worry. A recent intelligence report warns of a suicide bomber plan-

ning to target the Indian High Commission in Islamabad. This has prompted India's High Commissioner Satyabrata Pal to ask for extra security from the Pakistan government for the mission.

The tip-off states that the high commission is under threat from a militant group called

Tehrik Nifaz-e-Shariah-e-Muhammadi, which means "movement for the enforcement of Prophet Mohammad's Islamic laws". The group is known to mount suicide missions and is also referred to as a Pakistani Taliban, which was banned by the Musharraf regime in 2002. It has been running a parallel government in Pakistan's Swat district led by Maulana Fazlullah,

son-in-law of its founder Maulana Sofi Mohammad.

"We are fighting for a sacred cause and are ready to sacrifice our lives as it is the mission of Tehrik Nifaz Shariah Muhammadi," Moham-mad was quoted as saying. The cleric was released by the Pakistan Government last year. He had founded the group in 1992. Interestingly, Bhutto had vowed to curb the group's activities a few days before her killing. Its cadres are said to be targeting the mission dressed as armymen, policemen or as women in burqas.

For the jihadi groups that are bent on derailing the peace process between the two countries, targeting the Indian mission will be a big kill. It is high time that red taped bureaucracies on both sides set aside differences to guard against the common threat from terrorism. *by Saurabh Shukla*

## THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The armed forces had earmarked Rs 13 crore for upgradation of a hospital in Kerala. But when the proposal was placed before A.K. Antony, who is also from the state, his retort was, "I am the defence minister of India, not of Kerala."

## VOICES



"We don't enrol film stars into our party. They (film stars) are not interested in social service but are in the business of entertaining people."

Mayawati, Uttar Pradesh chief minister

"Everyone has a claim on Delhi. The exercise (of carrying an identification proof) smacks of discrimination. It will affect free movement of people across the capital."

Nitish Kumar, Bihar chief minister

"I am the senior-most Congressman. My firm view is that senior leaders such as Sharad Pawar should be brought back (to the Congress)."

K. Karunakaran, senior Congress leader

"Can you imagine Mahatma Gandhi controlling modern day terrorism? Terrorists are now trained not to attack a particular political entity, but destroy the entire civilisation."

K.P.S. Gill, former director-general of police, Punjab

"Financial support from the government is insufficient to build world class facilities and private sector money goes only to cricket."

Dola Banerjee, archery world champion

